THE FINESSE

ABOUT THE DEALS

You may be either Opener or Responder, but you will always be in the South position.

You are asked to study the Deal and mentally devise a Plan to make the contract.

FINESSE LESSON

Probably everybody reading this already knows what a Finesse is and uses them regularly. But a Lesson has to start somewhere, so here goes.

A Finesse is nothing more than an attempt to win a trick with a card which is not the highest one in the suit. It does its magic by being in the right position.

Look at the suit arrangement below.

♦ A Q x

♦ K x x ♦ x x x x

♦ x x x

Only a complete beginner in the South position would try to win two tricks by playing dummy's ♦A and hoping that a kindly opponent would put the ♦K underneath it. Any South who had played a few times would know that to win two tricks she must lead a small ♦x from her hand and play the ♦Q when West plays a low card.
That is a Finesse. A winning one as it happens.

Switch the ♦K from West to East.

♦ A Q x

♦ x x x ♦ K x x x

♦ x x x

Again you have to lead a small ♦x and put on the ♦Q when West plays low.
That is a losing Finesse.
Here is an important fact about the Simple Finesse:

> A SIMPLE FINESSE SUCCEEDS HALF
> THE TIME AND FAILS THE OTHER HALF

Look at those same suit arrangements from a different perspective.

♦ K x x

♦ A Q x ♦ x x x x

♦ x x x

This time South just hopes to win a single trick in the ♦ suit, and she won't do so by leading dummy's ♦K and hoping it sneaks through. No, she must lead a small ♦x from her hand toward the ♦K. If West plays a low card the ♦K will win the trick, and if West plays the ♦A then dummy's ♦K will live to win a

later trick.

A FINESSE WORKS BY LEADING TOWARD HIGH CARDS

The Simple Finesse:

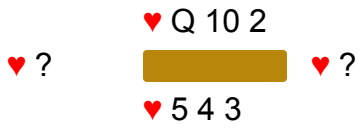
We've already talked about a Simple Finesse without actually defining it.
It is just a finesse which attempts to outfox a single card.

The ♦ A Q x and the ♦ K x x above are both examples of a Simple Finesse.
Here is another.



Now obviously you must lose the ♠A, so your modest goal is to try to win 2 tricks. If West holds the ♠J you can succeed with a Simple Finesse. Lead the ♠3 from your hand and when West plays a low card you insert dummy's ♠10. Either it will win the trick, leaving you and dummy with the ♠K ♠Q combination to drive out the ♠A, or else East will take the ♠10 with his ♠A, leaving you with two high ♠ tricks. Notice that you didn't care who held the ♠A, you just wanted West to hold the ♠J.

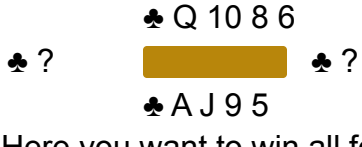
One more (of the thousands possible) before we leave the topic. This one is also a finesse of a Jack.



Things are getting desperate when you need a trick from this combination! Leading a small card with the intention of playing the ♥Q really is desperate - West would have to hold both the ♥ A K for this to work. A better finesse would be to play West for the ♥J and just one of the high honors. So you lead a low card and insert the ♥10, hoping that East must play the ♥A or ♥K to win the trick. Then, later, you play a low card from your hand toward the ♥Q, hoping that West has the other high honor.

Leading a High Card:

Sometimes you will have such good intermediate cards than you don't have to lead a low one for the finesse.



Here you want to win all four ♣ tricks so you will finesse East for the ♣K. But suppose you could only get to dummy one time? No problem. You lead the ♣Q and when East doesn't cover you underplay your ♣J. Still in dummy you play your ♣10, and if East plays low again you underplay your ♣9. You get the idea.

The Double Finesse:

Look at this:

♠ A Q 2
♥ A Q 2

♠ ?
♥ ?



♠ ?
♥ ?

♠ 5 4 3
♥ 5 4 3

This is **NOT** a Double Finesse, it is two Simple Finesses. But the principle is the same.
If you need four tricks here you have to hope that West holds both Kings. Not likely, it will only happen one fourth of the time.
But if you only need three tricks you are in luck. That means that West has to hold either of the Kings (or both) and that will happen three fourths of the time.

Compare that arrangement to this one:

♠ A Q 10

♠ ?



♠ ?

♠ 5 4 3

You play a low card from your hand and finesse the ♠10. If East has to win with the ♠K then you have your two tricks. But even if he wins with the ♠J you still have another chance to get back to your hand and try to finesse West out of his ♠K. If East had both honors you were just unlucky. But if West had both of them you should leave the Bridge table and go to Vegas.

Here is another Double Finesse situation:

♦ A J 10

♦ ?



♦ ?

♦ 5 4 3

This one doesn't look as good because dummy has the ♦J instead of the ♦Q. And sure enough, there is zero chance of making all three tricks here. But, when you are only looking to make two tricks you still have a 75% chance of success.
First finesse the ♦10, and when that loses to one of the big ones try another finesse with the ♦J. You will win two tricks whenever West started with either the ♦K, the ♦Q, or both of them.

The Deep Finesse:

This is sort of between a Simple and a Double Finesse:

♣ A J 9

♣ ?



♣ ?

♣ 5 4 3

Here you hope to win two tricks. If you finesse the ♣J you would win two tricks only when West started with ♣ K Q (x). The better way to play this combination is to lead low toward the ♣9, hoping that West started with either ♣ K 10 x or ♣ Q 10 x.

If you look back at the final example in the Simple Finesse section you will see that it was actually a Deep Finesse. Sometimes the plays overlap the names.

The Two-way Finesse:

The Two-way Finesse is almost always trying to guess a missing Queen.

♥ A J 2

♥ ? ♥ ?

♥ K 10 3

Of course you want all three tricks. Since you can finesse either opponent you should think about the bidding (if any), the opening lead, and any other inferences you might discover to help you decide which way to finesse. If you don't have any clues whatsoever, just pick one and finesse in that direction for a 50% chance.

The Ruffing Finesse:

Most of the time each of the finesse types can be used both in Notrump and Suit contracts.
The Ruffing Finesse can obviously only be used at Suit contracts.

♠ K Q J 2
♥ A 8 6 2

♠ ? ♠ ?
♥ ? ♥ ?

♠ --
♥ K Q J 3

With ♥s as trump you play the ♠K from dummy. If East puts on the ♠A you will ruff, establishing several ♠ winners in dummy. If East plays low you will discard a loser from some other suit.

The Chinese Finesse:

I have no idea how this play got its name. It is more correctly called a Pseudo-Finesse because it isn't a finesse at all, it is just a trick.
First look at this:

♣ A 7 3

♣ ? ♣ ?

♣ Q J 9

You can always win two tricks with this holding. But if you lead the ♣Q West may decide to cover with his ♣K. You could then win the ♣A, finesse East for the ♣10 and perhaps take all three tricks. West can prevent you from doing this simply by not covering your ♣Q but covering the ♣J if you lead it next.

But suppose this is your holding:

♣ A 7 3

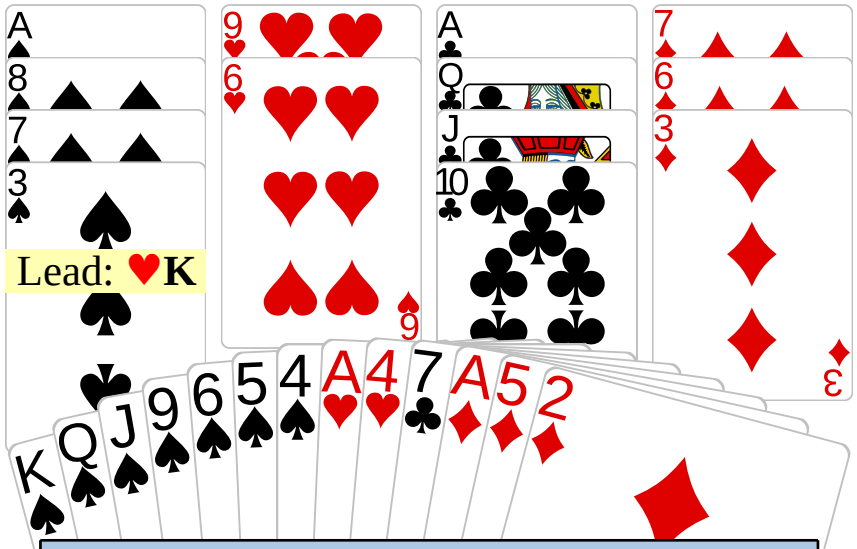
♣ ? ♣ ?

♣ Q 6

If you suspect West holds the ♣K you can try to trick him by leading your ♣Q. This is the Chinese Finesse. If he fears you have ♣ Q J 9 he may duck and wait to cover your ♣J when you lead it.

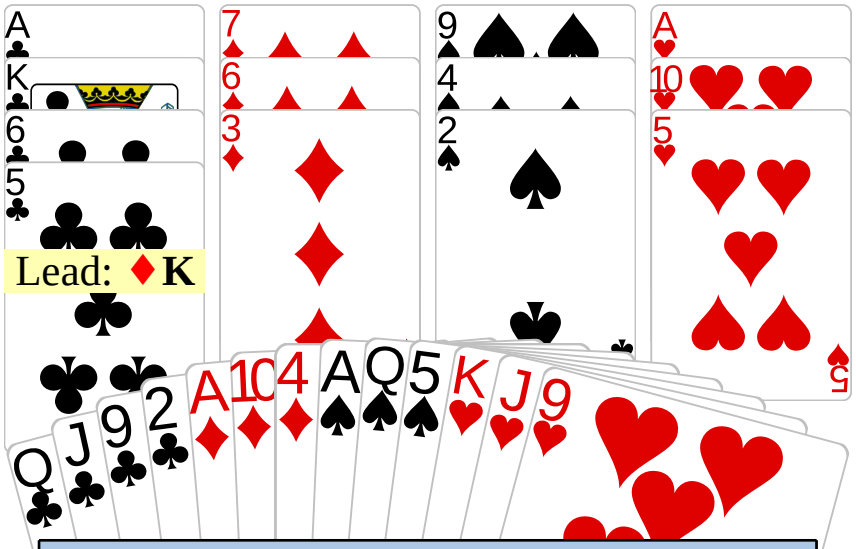
20 Practice Deals will be worth more than another 1000 words.

Deal 1 Ctr: **6♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



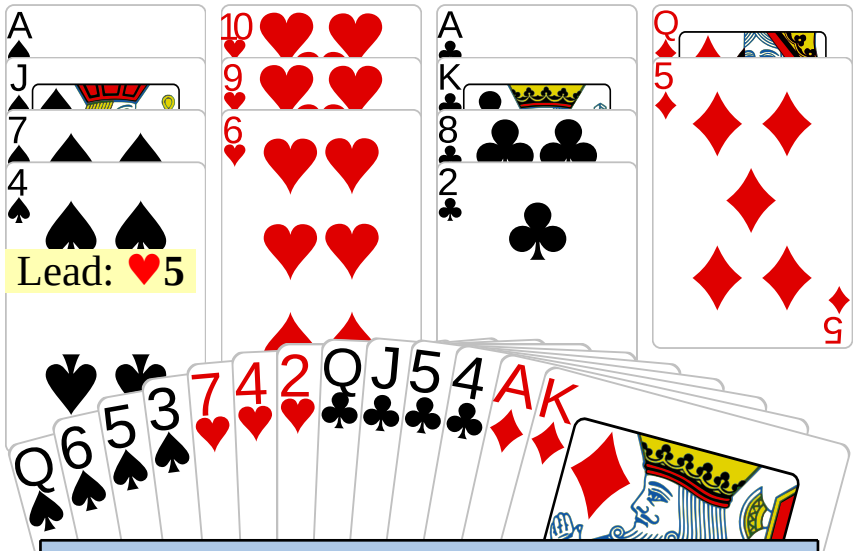
Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 2 Ctr: **3NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



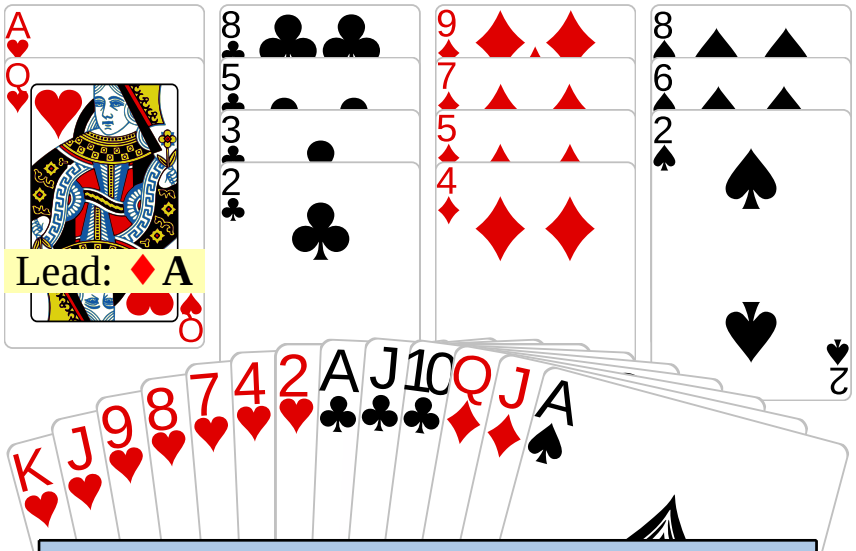
Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Deal 3 Ctr: **4♠** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 4 Ctr: **4♥** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 5 Ctr: **6♦** Goal: at most ____ losers



Count Fast and Slow Losers				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Reduce Losers				
Ruffs	Finesse	Pitch	Length	

Deal 6 Ctr: **7NT** Goal: at least ____ winners



Count Sure Winners				
♠	♥	♦	♣	Total
Decide How to Develop Winners				
Promotion	Length	Finesse	End Play	

Board: 1
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 6♠
Declarer: North
Lead: ♥K

Board: 2
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 3NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♦K

Board: 3
Dealer: **North**

Contract: 4♠
Declarer: South
Lead: ♥5

Board: 4
Dealer: **South**

Contract: 4♥
Declarer: West
Lead: ♦A

Board: 5
Dealer: **West**

Contract: 6♦
Declarer: North
Lead: ♣K

Board: 6
Dealer: **East**

Contract: 7NT
Declarer: East
Lead: ♠10

Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K Q J 9 6 5 4 ♥ A 4 ♦ A 5 2 ♣ 7	
♠ — ♥ 10 8 7 3 ♦ K J 9 4 ♣ K 8 6 5 2	N W E S	♠ 10 2 ♥ K Q J 5 2 ♦ Q 10 8 ♣ 9 4 3
	♠ A 8 7 3 ♥ 9 6 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A Q J 10	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4NT[1]	Pass	5♥[2]
Pass	6♠		
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 2 aces

6♠ by North
Lead: ♥K

North is to play 6♠. East leads the ♥K, dummy plays the ♥6 and West the ♥3.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=1 ♦=2 ♣=0 Total = 3

Your only hope for ridding yourself of two of those losers is dummy's ♣ suit. One possibility would be to finesse East for the ♣K, and if that works, discard your ♥ loser on the ♣A. You could then establish another ♣ winner for one of the ♦ losers. The problem with that plan is that if the finesse fails the defense will immediately take the setting ♥ trick.

A better plan is a ruffing finesse. Win the first trick with your ♥A and pull trumps with your ♠ K Q.

East plays low.

Your ♣7 to dummy's ♣A.

The ♣Q from dummy: a ruffing finesse. If West plays the ♣K you will ruff, enter dummy, and discard two red losers on the ♣ J 10. If West plays low instead, you discard your ♥ loser. East may be able to win the trick but you can ruff a ♥ return, and dummy will have two good ♣s on which you can discard 2 ♦ losers.

Ruffing finesses sometimes provide you the best opportunity, like this time.

But they are easy to overlook, mainly because we don't use them often.

Board 2
South Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ 10 8 7 6 ♥ 8 6 4 2 ♦ 8 2 ♣ 10 7 3	
♠ 9 4 2 ♥ A 10 5 ♦ 7 6 3 ♣ A K 6 5	N W E S	♠ A Q 5 ♥ K J 9 ♦ A 10 4 ♣ Q J 9 2
	♠ K J 3 ♥ Q 7 3 ♦ K Q J 9 5 ♣ 8 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			1♦
Pass	Pass	1NT	Pass
3NT			
All Pass			

3NT by East
Lead: ♦K

East is to play 3NT. South leads the ♦K, dummy plays the ♦3 and North the ♦2.

Winners: ♠=1 ♥=2 ♦=1 ♣=4 Total = 8

You only need one more winner. If North has the ♠K you can finesse him out of it. Or, you have a two-way finesse for the ♥Q.

It is an easy choice. The defenders only have 12 HCP and South opened the bidding. So you know he must have both of the cards you are interested in.

Then play four rounds of ♣s ending in your hand.

South continues with the ♦Q; dummy plays the ♦6 and North the ♦8.

South continues with the ♦J; dummy plays the ♦7 and North discards a ♠.

You held up the ♦A until the third round just to be safe.

You cash four rounds of ♣s, ending in your hand.

South covers with the ♥Q.

Now play the ♥J. If South doesn't cover, you will let it ride for your ninth trick. But South does cover so you take dummy's ♥A, then your other 2 ♥ tricks. The ♠A is your ninth trick.

You might think that a two-way finesse offers you a 50% chance of guessing correctly.

Sometimes that may be right. But there are other times when information from the bidding or the opening lead allows you to make a higher-percentage guess.

Board 3
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ A J 7 4 ♥ 10 9 6 ♦ Q 5 ♣ A K 8 2	
♠ K 2 ♥ K J 8 5 ♦ J 8 7 4 ♣ 10 6 3		♠ 10 9 8 ♥ A Q 3 ♦ 10 9 6 3 2 ♣ 9 7
	♠ Q 6 5 3 ♥ 7 4 2 ♦ A K ♣ Q J 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♠
Pass	2♠	Pass	4♠
All Pass			

4♠ by South
Lead: ♥5

South is to play 4♠. West leads the ♥5. The defense wins 3 ♥ tricks, then switches to a ♦.

Losers: ♠ = ? ♥ = 3 ♦ = 0 ♣ = 0 Total = 3 ?

You have already lost the 3 ♥ tricks so you must pick up the trump suit without loss.

West plays low.

The odds aren't in your favor, but you have no choice but to play West for the doubleton King.

So: a small ♠ from your hand, putting on the ♠J when West plays low. When this holds the trick plunk down the ♠A and hope.

This position is one that is misplayed very often.

Look what would have occurred if you had started with the ♠Q. West would have covered with the ♠K (if he had it) and you would have lost a trick to the ♠10 later.

The only hope is to try to drop the ♠K without wasting an extra honor.

Board 4
South Deals
Both Vul

	♠ Q J 9 7 ♥ 10 5 3 ♦ A K 10 6 ♣ Q 6	
♠ A ♥ K J 9 8 7 4 2 ♦ Q J ♣ A J 10	N W E S	♠ 8 6 2 ♥ A Q ♦ 9 7 5 4 ♣ 8 5 3 2
	♠ K 10 5 4 3 ♥ 6 ♦ 8 3 2 ♣ K 9 7 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
			Pass
1♥	Pass	1NT	Pass
4♥			
All Pass			

4♥ by West
Lead: ♦A

West is to play 4♥. North leads the ♦A. The defenders take two ♦ tricks, then switch to a trump.

Losers: ♠=0 ♥=0 ♦=2 ♣=2 Total = 4

The status is pretty clear, you've already lost the 2 ♦s so you have to keep your ♣ losers to just one. You have a good chance of pulling that off by playing for the ♣K and ♣Q to lie in different hands and taking two finesses.

South plays low.

You will only be in dummy once more, so you **MUST** make the first finesse right now: a small ♣ from dummy to your ♣10 (or ♣J). North wins with the ♣Q and plays another trump.

North leads the ♥5.

In dummy for the last time you must now take your second ♣ finesse.

South plays low.

A small ♣ to your remaining honour. When the ♣J wins you pull any leftover trumps and your hand is good.

This Deal is an excellent example of how and when to use the Double-Finesse, which gives you a 75% chance of success.

It was probably a better example of watching your entries. If you had pulled another trump before taking that first ♣ finesse you would not have been able to take the second one.

Board 5
West Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ A Q 5 ♥ A K 7 5 ♦ K Q 9 8 6 3 ♣ —	
♠ J 10 9 2 ♥ 10 9 8 ♦ 4 ♣ A J 9 5 3		♠ K 8 6 ♥ Q 4 3 2 ♦ 5 ♣ K Q 10 4 2
	♠ 7 4 3 ♥ J 6 ♦ A J 10 7 2 ♣ 8 7 6	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3♥	Pass	5♦
Pass	6♦		
All Pass			

6♦ by North
Lead: ♣K

North is to play 6♦. East leads the ♣K.

Losers: ♠=2 ♥=2 ♦=0 ♣=0 Total = 4

You don't really have 2 ♥ losers since both of them can be ruffed in dummy. The 2 ♠ losers are real, though, and must be dealt with. If West holds the ♠K then a simple finesse will win the contract for you. A 50% chance. But there is more to this Deal than a simple finesse, look at it carefully.

In addition to the trumps, dummy has another useful card, the ♥J.

You ruff the opening ♣ lead and pull trumps with the ♦K (they split 1-1).

East fidgets, then puts on the ♥Q.

A low ♥ toward the ♥J gives you a second chance, by playing East to hold the ♥Q. East plays another ♣, which you ruff.

You are in control now. You play a ♥ to dummy's ♥J, then a ♠ back to your ♠A. Discard dummy's 2 ♠ losers on the ♥ A K and claim your slam.

Suppose that it was West who held the ♥Q. Your ♥J would have been taken and you wouldn't get the two ♠ discards.

Then you would have to rely on the ♠ finesse after all. You'd be no worse off because you could still discard one of dummy's ♠s on a big ♥.

This method of play gave you two chances instead of just one.

Board 6
East Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 6 4 ♥ 10 9 5 4 2 ♦ 7 6 4 2 ♣ Q 5	
♠ K J 7 ♥ K 7 ♦ A J 10 8 ♣ K J 9 6	N W E S	♠ A Q 5 3 ♥ A J 8 ♦ K Q ♣ A 10 7 2
	♠ 10 9 8 2 ♥ Q 6 3 ♦ 9 5 3 ♣ 8 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		2NT	Pass
4♣	Pass	4NT	Pass
7NT			
All Pass			

7NT by East
Lead: ♠10

East is to play 7NT. South leads the ♠10.

Winners: ♠=4 ♥=2 ♦=4 ♣=2 Total = 12

A. Conan Doyle would have called this "The Tale of Two Queens". You need to find one more trick and to do so you are going to have to find either the ♥Q or the ♣Q. You can finesse North for the ♥Q, and you can finesse either defender for the ♣Q.

So which will you choose?

Neither, yet. First take your 8 winners in ♠s and ♦s, hoping somebody discards something to help you. They don't.

The ♣A and ♣K (in either order), hoping the ♣Q falls. If she does you have your thirteenth trick in ♣s. If she doesn't you take the ♥K then finesse North for the ♥Q. Two chances.

As you see, the ♥ finesse would have failed. You might have guessed the ♣Q correctly, but you might not have.

It always pays to look for a second chance. Here you try to drop the ♣Q, and if it doesn't work you have the finesse for the ♥Q in reserve.

Why not try to drop the ♥Q and keep the finesse for the ♣Q in reserve? Because you and dummy had 8 ♣s between you and only 6 ♥s. So the ♣Q was far more likely to be doubleton than the ♥Q.